Fiscal Year:	FY 2013	**Task Last Updated:**	FY 04/30/2013
PI Name:	Matin, A.C. Ph.D.		
Project Title:	Spaceflight Effects on Bacterial Antibiotic Resistance and Its Genetic Basis “AntimicrobialSat”		
Division Name:	Space Biology		
Program/Discipline:	SPACE BIOLOGY		
Program/Discipline--Element/Subdiscipline:	SPACE BIOLOGY--Cellular and molecular biology		
Joint Agency Name:		**TechPort:**	No
Human Research Program Elements:	None		
Human Research Program Risks:	None		
Space Biology Element:	(1) Cell & Molecular Biology (2) Microbiology		
Space Biology Cross-Element Discipline:	(1) Developmental Biology		
Space Biology Special Category:	(1) Translational (Countermeasure) Potential		
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City:	Stanford	**State:**	CA
Zip Code:	94305-5101	**Congressional District:**	14
Comments:			
Project Type:	Flight	**Solicitation / Funding Source:**	2008 SALMON--Astrobiology & FSB NNH08ZDA009O-SCMAFSB
Start Date:	07/01/2010	**End Date:**	11/30/2014
No. of Post Docs:	1	**No. of PhD Degrees:**	0
No. of PhD Candidates:	1	**No. of Master' Degrees:**	0
No. of Master's Candidates:	0	**No. of Bachelor's Degrees:**	0
No. of Bachelor's Candidates:	0	**Monitoring Center:**	NASA ARC
Contact Monitor:	Smith, Jeffrey	**Contact Phone:**	650-604-0880
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Flight Program:	Small Satellites		
Flight Assignment:	NOTE: New end date is 11/30/2014 per NSSC information (Ed., 4/4/14) NOTE: New end date is 4/30/2014 per A. Chu/ARC and NSSC (Ed., 2/21/2013)		
Key Personnel Changes/Previous PI:	None		
COI Name (Institution):			
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Performance Goal No.:			
Performance Goal Text:			

Task Description:

This project is concerned with the design, development, and testing of a nanosatellite payload, and the proposed biological experiment after launch in 2013. As in the past, the NASA and Stanford teams have worked closely in this project period to optimize the experimental conditions and ensure the success of the experiment in space. This includes weekly conference calls, visits by the parties to each other's institutions, and regular discussion in more formal setting in the presence of other NASA staff. The two component personnel have enjoyed a close, pleasant and productive interactive relationship.
As dramatized in the movie Apollo 13, astronauts during spaceflight can contract bacterial infections. Astronauts in space have also experienced infections with other opportunistic and pathogenic microbes. Effective treatment of bacterial infections has required therapy customized for the space environment, as evidence has accumulated that microbes respond differently to antimicrobials in the space environment (1). The EcAMSat experiment focus on directly documenting alterations in antibiotic resistance in the space environment using a well-defined microbial system - the bacterium, E. coli, and a widely-used antibiotic, gentamicin, against a uropathogenic strain of this bacterium.

Integrated bioreactors have flown on manned spacecraft; they require humans to initiate experiments, record data, and collect or prepare samples to return them to Earth for characterization. Fully autonomous microsystems like EcAMSat reduce the cost and obviate other limitations of human-tended space biological experiments, while expanding significantly the number of launch opportunities (2).

The Matin group has shown in Earth experiments that bacterial antibiotic resistance depends on their intact innate resistance, whose central regulator is the stress sigma factor, Sigma S (ss). Further, our studies with simulated microgravity obtained using high aspect ratio (HARV) bioreactors, have shown that in stationary phase, the bacterial antibiotic resistance is greatly enhanced, again dependent on this sigma factor (encoded by the rpoS gene) (3). Our recent findings have identified several proteins controlled by this sigma factor that determine E. coli resistance to gentamicin (4). Future work to assess the role of these genes in space can be expected to provide further novel means of countering bacterial resistance in space.

EcAMSat's 14 kg mass comprises a structure roughly 10 x 22 x 34 cm, including triple-junction solar cells; patch antenna for 2.4-GHz bidirectional communication using a commercial WiFi-technology radio; self-deploying omnidirectional "beacon" antenna for spacecraft location and education-and-outreach broadcasting on the amateur ("ham") band (437.465 MHz); mechanical structure; spacecraft power/processor/communications/control system (collectively, the "bus"); and the experiment containment vessel, internal volume 1.2 L, which houses the bio/fluidic, opti-cal, thermal, sensor, and payload electronics subsystems. Magnetic rods passively orient the satellite, aiming the spacecraft's long axis and hence the patch antenna towards Earth's north magnetic pole during the part of each ~93-minute orbital period when the spacecraft is above the northern hemisphere. Magnetic hysteresis rods damp nutation or "wobble" in spacecraft motion by dissipating energy as heat when they move across Earth's magnetic field lines.

The EcAMSat fluidic system includes forty-eight 100-µL culture wells, each 4 mm in diameter x 7.8 mm deep. Use of 9-mm pitch along the rows and 9- and 13.5-mm center-to-center row spacing allows fluidic card optical analysis with standard multiwell plate readers. The fluidic card was fabricated by Micronics, Inc. from laser-cut poly(methylmethacrylate) layers laminated to one another using pressure-sensitive acrylic adhesive interlayers supported on PET (poly(ethylene terephthalate)) carrier films. Four independent sets of manifolded fluidic inlets and outlets supply nutrients and antibiotic agent to the four 12-well banks. Bacterial cells are confined in the microwells by integral 0.2-µm pore-size nylon fiber membrane filters (Sterlitech). The NASA group with Stanford participation and input has continued to develop and test the nanosatellite payload, including the biological experiment that will test the hypothesis that stress response to the spaceflight microgravity environment enhances antibiotic resistance in uropathogenic E. coli (UPEC) in a manner dependent on its stress transcriptional factor, ss. Based on the results, a protocol has been developed for the space experiments.

The pressure values for introducing various fluids into microwells is nearly optimized and the full protocol will begin to be tested on Earth in the next few weeks. Also, a standard curve for survival of starving experimental bacteria is being determined to fend for unforeseen alteration in the stowage period before the commencement of the flight. Similarly, preparations are being made for parallel control experiments on Earth during the space flight.

EcAMSat's "2U" payload will support wild-type UPEC and its isogenic rpoS mutant (lacking sS, which is encoded by the rpoS gene) in four independent banks of 12 100-µL wells (6 wells each for wild-type and mutant) in a microfluidic card that delivers nutrient, confines cells using integral 0.2-µm-pore filters, and maintains temperature (37 °C). Each microwell (pathlength: 8 mm) has a dedicated 3-color LED and photodetector to track growth of the organisms via light scattering (470 nm). Cellular metabolism is tracked using Alamar Blue indicator dye (615 nm) and its reduced form (525 nm), generated by bacterial metabolism.

Growth and metabolism of E. coli are measured versus the concentration of the antibiotic gentamicin (four well banks provide three concentrations and a control). Following orbital stabilization, bacteria in stasis are given nutrient and grown to stationary phase, the phase most important in disease causation. The bacteria are then rinsed with nutrient-free buffer and starved for 24 hr (to firm up the innate resistance of stationary phase cells). Finally, they are treated with gentamicin for 24 hours, followed by tracking survival dynamically via Alamar Blue. We have performed detailed baseline and feasibility experiments, showing that Alamar Blue measurements reliably indicate the increased sensitivity of the mutant to gentamicin.

Two abstracts have been published (5,6), and two submitted (7,8).

1. Principles of Clinical Medicine for Space Flight M. R. Barratt, S. L. Pool, Eds. (Springer, New York, ed. 1, 2008).

2. Ricco, A.J., Hines, J.W., Piccini, M., Parra, M., Timucin, L., Barker, V., Storment, C., Friedericks, C., Agasid, E., Beasley, C., Giovangrandi, L., Henschke, M., Kitts, C., Levine, L., Luzzi, E., Ly, D., Mas, I., Mclntyre, M., Oswell, D., Rasay, R., Ricks, R., Ronzano, K., Squires, D., Swaiss, G., Tucker, J., and Yost, B., "Autonomous genetic analysis system to study space effects on microorganisms: Results from orbit," Proc. Transducers 2007, IEEE: New York (2007); pp. 33-37.

3. Singh, R, and Matin, A C. unpublished

4. Submitted, PLoS Biology

5. EcAMSat: Nanosatellite Microfluidic Payload Determines Spaceflight Effects on Bacterial Antibiotic Resistance and Their Genetic Basis (2012) A.C. Matin, A.J. Ricco, M. Parra, K. Ronzano, M. Lera, D. Wu, M. Tan, S. Ross, M.

	Keyhan, C. Mayberry, C. Beasley, and S. Choi, 28th Annual Meeting of the American Society for Gravitational and Space Research, New Orleans, 11/28-12/2/12, abstr TVI-6. 6. Newly Modified Microfluidics Hardware with Flight Heritage Provides Platform for Conducting Inexpensive On-Orbit Microbiology Experiments (2012) M. Lera, M. Parra, D. Wu, M. Tan, A. J. Ricco, K. Ronzano, S. Ross, C. Mayberry, C. Beasley, S. Choi, A.C. Matin, and M. Keyhan, 28th Annual Meeting of the American Society for Gravitational and Space Research, New Orleans, 11/28-12/2/12, abstr IPS-14. 7. EcAMSat: Nanosatellite Microfluidic Payload Determines Spaceflight Effects on Bacterial Antibiotic Resistance and Their Genetic Basis. A.C. Matin, A.J. Ricco, M. Parra, K. Ronzano, M. Lera, D. Wu, M. Tan, S. Ross, M. Keyhan, C. Mayberry, C. Beasley, S. Choi, M. Benoit, J. Wang, R. Singh. CASIS meeting, Colorado, May 2013. 8. A.C. Matin, A.J. Ricco, M. Parra, K. Ronzano, M. Lera, D. Wu, M. Tan, S. Ross, M. Keyhan, C. Mayberry, C. Beasley, S. Choi, M. Benoit, J. Wang, R. Singh. Nanosatellite microfluidic payload will determine spaceflight effects on bacterial antibiotic resistance and its genetic basis. ELGRA Annual Meeting. Rome, Italy, September 2013.
Rationale for HRP Directed Research:	
Research Impact/Earth Benefits:	Antibiotic resistance in bacteria is becoming an extremely serious problem on Earth which will impact space travellers as well (the astronauts carry with them the Earth microflora). The research underway will provide a critical test for a hypothesis, which if confirmed, will show the way to greatly mitigate bacterial resistance to antibiotics in general. This hypothesis is based on a firm foundation provided by experiments conducted on Earth; and since bacterial resistance increases under microgravity conditions, its testing in space provides an amplified situation where the difference made by the absence of the gene responsible can be seen more clearly. The innovative technology that is being developed is a generation of small molecules that can silence the gene in question, which can then either be used alone (since the resulting weakened bacteria can be more easily dealt with by the immune system) or in combination with existing antibiotics for effective treatment of infectious disease here on Earth as well as in space.
Task Progress:	The NASA group with Stanford participation and input has continued to develop and test the nanosatellite payload, including the biological experiment that will test the hypothesis that stress response to the spaceflight microgravity environment enhances antibiotic resistance in uropathogenic E. coli (UPEC) in a manner dependent on its stress transcriptional factor, ss. Based on the results summarized in Table 1, a protocol has been developed for the space experiments (Table 2). Table 1. Stowage period factors • Gentamicin retains 50% potency; load concentration will take this into account. • Bacterial viability (M9 salts); 70 day stowage: WT, 0.7%; Sigma S mutant, 0.3%. • As the desired starting inoculum is ±1.2x108 cells/ml, the load concentration will be around 1.7x1010 and 4x1010/ml for the wt & the mutant respectively. • Alamar Blue potency is unaffected. Table 2. Proposed protocol for space experiments 1. Add 1/8th potency LB to initiate growth. 2. After 12 h (final A600 : ca. 0.5), wash in M9. 3. Starve in M9 for 24 h (to induce innate resistance). 4. Add gentamicin (aged antibiotic to equal three concentrations around 16 µg/ml). 5. Incubate 24 h. 6. M9 washing step desirable. 7. Add Alamar Blue to determine activity. The pressure values for introducing various fluids into microwells is nearly optimized and the full protocol will begin to be tested on Earth in the next few weeks. Also, a standard curve for survival of starving experimental bacteria is being determined to fend for unforeseen alteration in the stowage period before the commencement of the flight. Similarly, preparations are being made for parallel control experiments on Earth during the space flight.
Bibliography Type:	Description: (Last Updated: 03/27/2020)
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Abstracts for Journals and Proceedings	Matin AC, Ricco AJ, Parra M, Ronzano K, Lera M, Wu D, Tan M, Ross S, Keyhan M, Mayberry C, Beasley C, Choi S, Benoit M, Wang J, Singh R. "Nanosatellite Microfluidic Payload Determines Spaceflight Effects on Bacterial Antibiotic Resistance and Their Genetic Basis." 2nd Annual International Space Stations Research & Development Conference, Denver, Colorado, July 16-18, 2013. Bacterial resistance in microgravity and equipment for testing this on a nanosatellite. 2nd Annual International Space Stations Research & Development Conference, Denver, Colorado, July 16-18, 2013. In press as of May 2013. , May-2013